

3.2 Improvements and further developments

Constraints which limit the effectiveness of characters and comics

- Character and comic constraints
 - time
 - resource
 - hardware
 - software
 - skills
- Character improvements
 - unmet areas of client brief
 - target audience considerations/engagement that need to be better fulfilled
- Comic improvements
 - unmet areas of client brief
 - target audience considerations/engagement that need to be better fulfilled
 - accessibility improvements

Further development opportunities for characters and comics

- Further developments
 - comic sequel/next editions
 - themed editions
 - storyline serialisation/cliff-hanger endings
 - character development/additions
 - spin off products: books, TV, film, merchandise

To include:

- How the quality of created comics is constrained by time, resource, hardware, software, skills
- The feasible improvements to created characters and comics in terms of client requirements and target audience engagement

To include:

- How successful characters and comics can lead to repeat business/further commissions from clients
- How different resources, software, budget and skills could help characters and comics to be developed further
- How to devise further developments in terms of client requirements and target audiences

Marking criteria

[Section 6.4](#) provides full information on how to mark the NEA units and apply the marking criteria. The marking criteria descriptor words are further explained in [Appendix B](#).

The tables below contain the marking criteria for the tasks for this unit. If a student's work does not meet any Mark Band 1 (MB1) criteria for the task, you must award zero marks for that task.

Unit R095 – Topic Area 1: Plan characters and comics		
MB1: 1–2 marks	MB2: 3–4 marks	MB3: 5–6 marks
Produces a basic interpretation of the client brief. Explanation of how the intended product meets the client brief and why it appeals to the target audience is limited .	Produces an adequate interpretation of the client brief. Explanation of how the intended product meets the client brief and why it appeals to the target audience is sound .	Produces an effective interpretation of the client brief. Explanation of how the intended product meets the client brief and why it appeals to the target audience is comprehensive .
MB1: 1–3 marks	MB2: 4–6 marks	MB3: 7–8 marks
Produces basic pre-production and planning documentation. Pre-production and planning documentation support the creation of few elements of the final product.	Produces adequate pre-production and planning documentation. Pre-production and planning documentation support the creation of some elements of the final product.	Produces detailed pre-production and planning documentation. Pre-production and planning documentation support the creation of all elements of the final product.
MB1: 1–2 marks	MB2: 3–4 marks	MB3: 5–6 marks
Demonstrates limited understanding of how assets will contribute to the effectiveness of the final product.	Demonstrates sound understanding of how assets will contribute to the effectiveness of the final product.	Demonstrates comprehensive understanding of how assets will contribute to the effectiveness of the final product.

MB1: 1–4 marks	MB2: 5–8 marks	MB3: 9–12 marks
Use of technical skills to create the component parts is limited in its effectiveness. Conventions and creativity in the components are limited in their fitness for purpose. The range of components supports the creation of the final product in a limited way.	Use of technical skills to create the component parts is partly effective. Conventions and creativity in the components are adequate in their fitness for purpose. The range of components partly supports the creation of the final product.	Use of technical skills to create the component parts is effective. Conventions and creativity in the components are fully fit for purpose. The range of components fully supports the creation of the final product.
MB1: 1–5 marks	MB2: 6–10 marks	MB3: 11–14 marks
Use of technical skills to create the final product is limited in its effectiveness. Conventions and creativity are applied in the final product in a limited way. Final product is limited in its fitness for purpose.	Use of technical skills to create the final product is partly effective. Conventions and creativity are adequately applied in the final product. Final product is adequately fit for purpose.	Use of technical skills to create the final product is effective. Conventions and creativity are effectively applied in the final product. Final product is fully fit for purpose.
MB1: 1–3 marks	MB2: 4–6 marks	MB3: 7–8 marks
Formats of the saved/exported components are limited in their appropriateness. Properties and format(s) of the final product are limited in their appropriateness.	Formats of the saved/exported components are adequate in their appropriateness. Properties and format(s) of the final product are adequate in their appropriateness.	Formats of the saved/exported components are clearly appropriate. Properties and format(s) of the final product are clearly appropriate.

MB1: 1–3 marks	MB2: 4–7 marks	MB3: 8–10 marks
Testing/checking is limited in its effectiveness in reviewing technical properties. Review demonstrates limited understanding of the effectiveness of the final product for client and target audience.	Testing/checking is partly effective in reviewing technical properties. Review demonstrates sound understanding of the effectiveness of the final product for client and target audience.	Testing/checking is fully effective in reviewing technical properties. Review demonstrates critical understanding of the effectiveness of the final product for client and target audience.
MB1: 1–2 marks	MB2: 3–4 marks	MB3: 5–6 marks
Recommendations demonstrate limited understanding of areas for improvement and further development. Recommendations have limited explanation.	Recommendations demonstrate sound understanding of areas for improvement and further development. Recommendations are partly explained.	Recommendations demonstrate comprehensive understanding of areas for improvement and further development. Recommendations are fully explained.

Task 1

Strand 1a

For Mark Band (MB)1, students may have simply stated the chosen audience and restated the client. An explanation of the content or chosen style of the character and comic with reference to the client brief would be more appropriate for MB2 or MB3. An explanation of only one or two ways in which the intended product meets the client brief and appeals to the target audience would be suitable for MB1. MB3 could be achieved by explaining a few ways in great detail (depth) or by explaining many ways concisely (breadth). Diagrammatic representations would illustrate the interpretation, but would not be sufficient on their own to fulfil the requirement to explain for the upper mark bands.

When interpreting the brief, students need to make decisions independently. Although it is to be expected that different students may make similar decisions and develop similar ideas, it would be highly unusual for all students in a cohort to have identical work.

Strand 1b

Pre-production documentation for the character and comic could be presented in a number of different formats. Basic planning for MB1 may cover only an outline of the character and an indication of the design of the comic, whereas detailed planning for MB3 would be expected to include depth. Demonstrating in detail the design of the character, comic content and layout would be one way to meet the upper MB criteria. It would be unlikely for any single pre-production document to cover 'all' elements of the final character and comic, and different types of planning document would be expected in order to show features of the character and both the layout and content of the comic to meet the criteria for the higher mark bands.

Students must not be directed to complete specific planning tasks but may be referred to the teaching and learning content for the unit. When planning their character and comic and justifying their design choices, students need to make decisions independently. Although it is to be expected that different students may make similar decisions and develop similar ideas, it would be highly unusual for all students in a cohort to have identical work.

Strand 1c

This strand requires students to demonstrate understanding of how assets contribute to the effectiveness of the character and comic. A list of assets could be suitable for credit in MB1, but would not demonstrate understanding. A consideration of the technical properties of the assets chosen and reference to how the style or type of assets would appeal to the target audience or match the conventions of the product genre would be more appropriate for the requirements for MB3.

Task 2

Strand 2a

The component parts in this instance are the visual elements and text-based assets. When creating the components, technical skills might be used to make sure suitable formats and sizes are used. The visual assets may be combined using appropriate software and technical skills in order to meet the criteria for MB3. Credit for digital graphics skills would be relevant for the upper mark bands when creating the visual component parts. Fitness for purpose in terms of conventions and creativity for MB3 could be credited if the content matches the genre and requirements set out in the client brief. Where components are a poor match in terms of genre or type, a mark in the lower band would be suitable. To fully support the creation of the final product for MB3, assets would need to be complete and technically fit for purpose. Few assets or types, or many assets but with limited technical suitability would be appropriately assessed in MB1.

Strand 2b

For MB1, the final product may be simplistic, incomplete or limited in its suitability as a comic that tells a story. Some evidence of the tools used to create the character and comic would support marks for this strand particularly if the product is not finished or exported. Students might present screenshots to show the technical skills and tools of the software in use during the creation process. This is particularly helpful to credit some marks if the editing software is unavailable to assessors and the final product is not exported. An original idea which does not follow the conventions of comic and character design would fit the criteria for MB1 in this strand for the conventions and creativity used. For the upper mark bands both originality and conventions should be evident in the character and comic. The criteria for fitness for purpose can be credited if the final product is suitable for the requirements specified by the client. Typographical errors and omissions would limit fitness for purpose and so the mark for this criterion would not be placed in the upper band.

When creating their character and comic, students must make decisions independently. They must apply what they have learnt and not be led through a process to create an animation with audio. Students must not be directed to use particular software or software tools and/or techniques.

Strand 2c

This strand assesses the appropriateness of the components and the final product (the finished comic). In order to meet the criteria for MB3, the character, assets and the comic should all be saved using appropriate formats and properties and saved suitably for the client to access. Where the comic is not exported from the native software, MB1 would be appropriate. For MB3, the naming of the final comic file to demonstrate relevance to the client would be one way to make sure it is clearly appropriate.

When exporting their character and comic, students need to independently decide on suitable electronic formats and properties.

Task 3

Students must produce their own review applying what they have learnt and not be led through a process of reviewing their completed character and comic.

Strand 3a

At MB1 this may only outline a few checks, or may be limited by checking only some aspects. If results of the checks and re-checks are considered this would contribute to MB2, whereas to be fully effective for MB3 the technical properties should be considered comprehensively. An outline of how errors were resolved or prioritised for resolution would be appropriate for the upper end of the mark range. The second descriptor assesses understanding of the effectiveness of the character and comic for the client and target audience. If only the client or target audience are considered, a mark in MB1 may be suitable, whereas for MB3 both client and target audience, and the character and comic should be considered. Students may have explained how and why the character and comic would be effective. A list of checks on its own would not evidence understanding of effectiveness, only functionality; so, some form of account or explanation would be expected for MB2 and MB3.

Strand 3b

This strand requires an understanding of areas for improvement and further development, and an explanation of the recommendations. A list of aspects which underperformed when checked would demonstrate limited understanding for MB1. For MB3 students may have prioritised aspects to be addressed. Explaining which are the most important and why might be one way to demonstrate comprehensive understanding. Areas for improvement and further development should be explained with reference to the client requirements and target audience engagement in order to demonstrate comprehensive understanding for MB3, and should include both the character created and the final comic. If the only the character or comic are considered, a mark in MB1 would be suitable. Since there is no requirement for a prescribed number of improvements and developments, a few aspects considered and explained in detail could nevertheless meet the criteria for MB3.

Topic Area		Topic Area	
1	Plan characters and comics	2	Factors influencing product design
		3	Pre-production planning
2	Create characters and comics	3	Pre-production planning
		4	Distribution considerations
3	Review characters and comics	2	Factors influencing product design
		3	Pre-production planning
		4	Distribution considerations

More information about synoptic assessment within this qualification can be found in [section 5.2 Synoptic assessment](#).